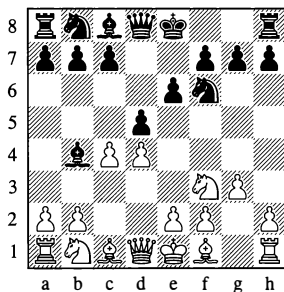


Chapter 12

Catalan 4...♞b4†



Various 5th Moves

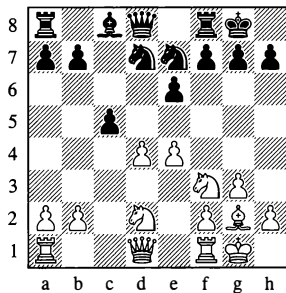
Variation Index

1.d4 ♞f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♞f3 ♞b4†

5.♞d2

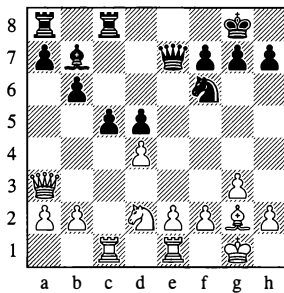
A) 5...c5	170
B) 5...♞xd2† 6.♞bxd2 0-0 7.♞g2	171
B1) 7...♞e7	171
B2) 7...b6	173
B3) 7...c6	174
C) 5...♞d6 6.♞c3!	176
C1) 6...c6	176
C2) 6...0-0	178

B) note to move 7



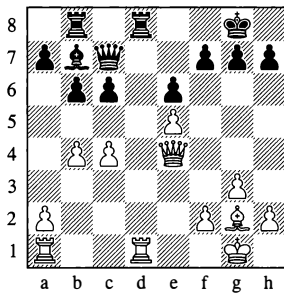
11.dxc5!N

B1) after 15...♞b7



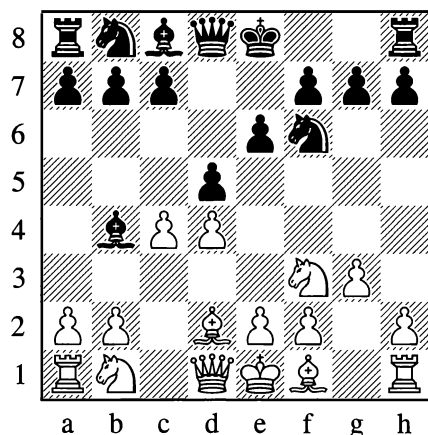
16.dxc5!N

B3) note to 10...♞b7



17.c5!N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♙b4† 5.♙d2



From this position the most common continuation has been 5...♙e7, hoping to show that the bishop is misplaced on d2. In this chapter we will consider the three main alternatives: A) 5...c5, B) 5...♙xd2† and C) 5...♙d6.

5...♙e7 looks odd with the pawn already committed to d5, and after 6.♙g2 Black will probably end up with an inferior version of some other Catalan or Bogo variation.

5...a5 6.♙g2 transposes exactly to variation C of Chapter 19, although Black can also change directions with 6...dxc4, in which case we transpose to 4...dxc4 5.♙g2 ♙b4† 6.♙d2 a5, which was covered in variation D of Chapter 4.

A) 5...c5

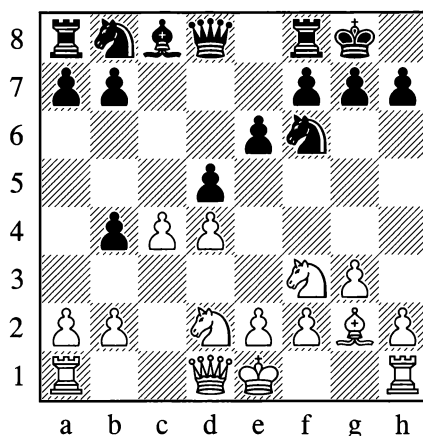
This is pretty rare, but it seems quite playable.

6.♙xb4

The alternative 6.cxd5 exd5 7.♙g2 0–0 8.0–0 ♘c6 does not give Black as many problems.

6...cxb4 7.♘bd2 0–0 8.♙g2

This position might also arise from the Bogo-Indian with 4...c5. In that variation, however, Black normally plays the more flexible ...d6. I believe the set-up with the pawn on d5 to be slightly inferior, and White should get easy play with mostly natural moves.

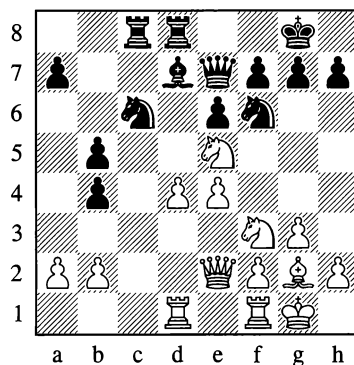


8...♘c6 9.0–0

Many games have been played from this position. I will present a few instructive examples to show White's ideas.

9...b6

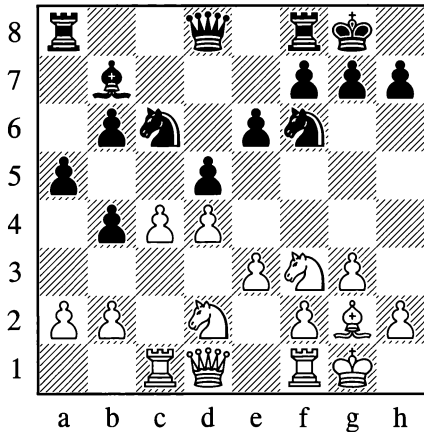
9...♙e7 10.♙c2 ♙d8 11.♙ad1!? (11.♙fd1 looks like a good alternative) 11...♙d7 12.e4 dxc4 13.♘xc4 ♙ac8 14.♙e2 b5 15.♘ce5±



White had a nice positional edge in Sumets – Haroutjunian, Neustadt an der Weinstrasse 2012.

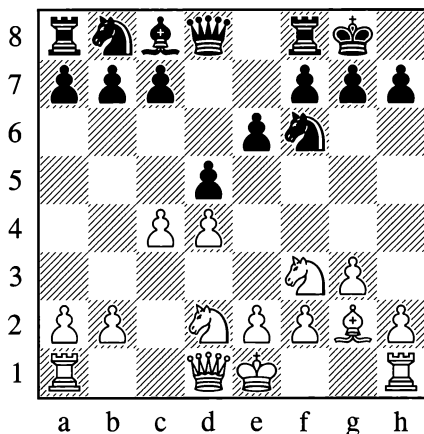
10.♖c1 ♜b7 11.e3 a5

11...♞d6 12.♞a4 ♜fc8 13.♞c2 occurred in Ivanchuk – Gulko, New York 1988. White followed up with 14.♜fc1 and, step by step, Black came under serious pressure.



**12.cxd5 ♘xd5 13.♘c4 ♜c8 14.e4 ♘f6
15.♞d3 ♜a6 16.♞fd1 ♘e7 17.♘fe5±**

White had a pleasant edge, with a better pawn structure and excellent central control in Maiwald – Hertneck, Germany 2013.

B) 5...♜xd2† 6.♘bxd2 0–0 7.♜g2

Black's 5th move seems like a concession, as he swaps off his more active bishop while facilitating White's development. Nevertheless,

several top GMs have played this way, so I will analyse it in a bit more detail than in *GM 1*. Black's three main moves are **B1) 7...♞e7**, **B2) 7...b6** and **B3) 7...c6**.

There is also:

7...♘bd7 8.0–0 c5

8...c6 leads straight to variation B3.

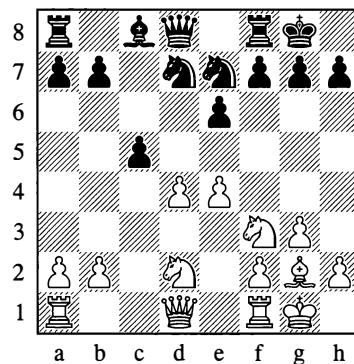
9.cxd5 ♘xd5 10.e4

This is more ambitious than 10.dxc5 ♘xc5 11.♖c1 b6, when Black had a decent game in Cheparinov – Naiditsch, Bol 2013.

10...♘e7

10...♘5f6 11.e5 ♘d5 occurred in Astrakhantsev – Shutemov, Dagomys 2004, and now 12.♞e1N would have been most accurate. Play may continue 12...b6 13.♘e4 ♜b7 14.♘d6 ♜b8 (14...♜c6? 15.♞c1±) 15.♘d2 cxd4 16.♘2c4± and White remains on top.

Now in Ibrahim – Malkawi, Beirut 2007, White could have claimed an edge with:



11.dxc5!N ♘xc5 12.♞c2

The c5-knight is more of a target than a strength, for instance:

12...b6 13.♞fd1 ♜b7 14.b4 ♘a6 15.♞b3

White's space advantage definitely counts.

B1) 7...♞e7 8.0–0 b6

Another possible set-up is:

8...♞d8 9.♞c2 ♘c6

This looks a bit too passive, and White should get easy play by carrying out the thematic e2-e4 advance.

I also paid attention to 9...c5 10.cxd5 cxd4 11.♘xd4 ♘xd5, as in Balog – Kotic, Budapest 2009, and now the simple 12.♖fd1N ♙d7 13.♘c4 ♙e8 14.e4 ♘b6 15.♘a5 ♘a6 16.a3± retains a pleasant edge for White.

10.♖ad1 ♙d7

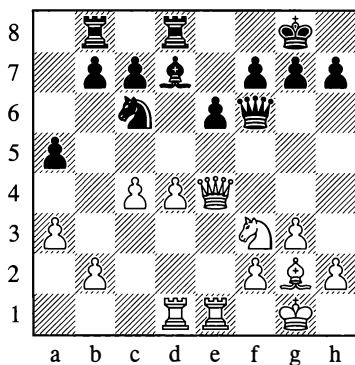
Another good example continued 10...a5 11.♖fe1 ♙d7 12.e4 ♘b4 13.♖b1 dxc4 14.♘xc4 ♙b5 15.♘e3± and White was beautifully centralized in Postny – Radulski, Barcelona 2008.

11.a3 a5 12.e4

It is generally not a good sign for Black that White is managing to play e2-e4 so easily.

12...dxe4 13.♘xe4 ♘xe4 14.♖xe4 ♖ab8 15.♖fe1 ♖f6

In Jovanic – Zelcic, Otocac 2010, White could have increased his advantage with:

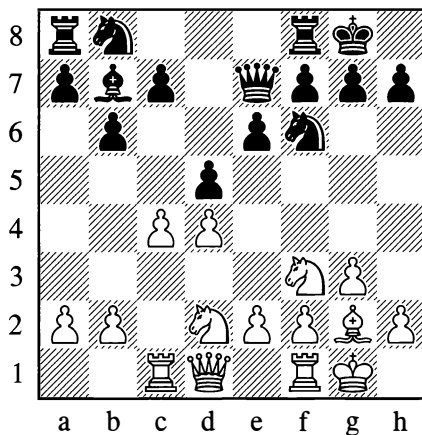


16.d5!N exd5 17.cxd5 ♘a7 18.♘e5 ♙e8 19.♖c2±

The difference in piece coordination is obvious.

9.♖c1 ♙b7

With the bishop committed to b7, this is a good moment for White to remove the tension in the centre.



10.cxd5 exd5

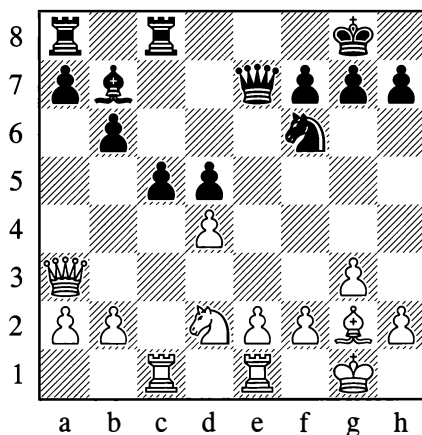
10...♙d5?! 11.♖e1 threatens e2-e4, and after 11...♘e4 12.♘xe4 ♙xe4 13.♖a4!± Black will find it hard to develop the knight from b8.

11.♖a4 c5

After 11...a5?! 12.♖fe1 c6 13.e4! ♘xe4 14.♘xe4 dxe4 15.♘e5 White obtained a dangerous initiative thanks to his development advantage in Salov – I. Sokolov, Amsterdam 1996.

12.♘e5 ♖c8 13.♖fe1 ♘c6 14.♘xc6 ♙xc6 15.♖a3 ♙b7

We have been following the game Philippeit – Pukropski, email 2010. This would have been a good moment to define the central structure with:

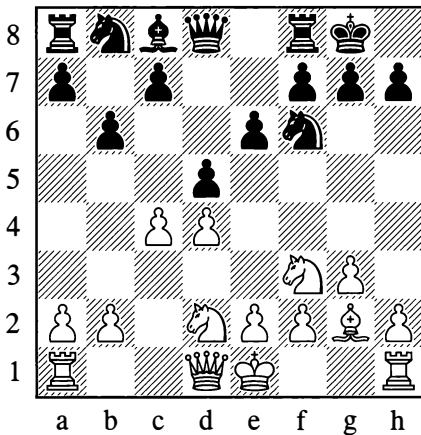


16.dxc5! Nxc5

16...bxc5? runs into 17.♖b3 ♕d7 18.♗h3± when Black loses at least a pawn.

17.♖c3 ♖f8 18.♖ec1 ♖xc3 19.♖xc3 ♖xa3 20.♖xa3±

Black has to defend an inferior endgame.

B2) 7...b6**8.cxd5**

Good timing! If White delays this exchange, then Black will have the additional option of recapturing with the bishop on d5.

8...exd5

8...♗xd5 does not equalize, as the following recent game convincingly demonstrates: 9.0–0 ♗b7 10.♖c1 ♗d7 11.e4 ♗5f6 12.♖e2 ♖c8 13.♖fd1 ♖e7 14.e5 ♗d5 15.♗e4 h6 16.a3 a5 17.h4± White got a significant advantage in Cernousek – Bokros, Slovakia 2014.

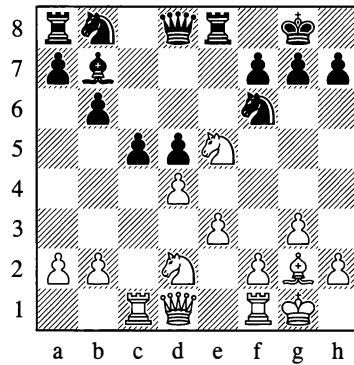
9.0–0 ♗b7 10.♖c1

This is the most natural. I would also like to mention 10.b4 c6 11.♖c2N ♗bd7 12.a4, when I believe White can claim a modest edge.

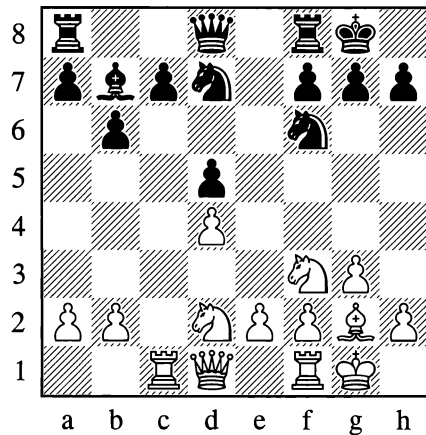
10...♗bd7

10...♖e8 demands a new approach from White: 11.♗e5!?N (11.♖e1 was played in Postny – Huzman, Beer Sheva [rapid] 2013,

but there is no need to commit the rook so soon) 11...c5 (11...♗bd7?! would allow 12.♗c6) 12.e3



12...♗bd7 (12...cxd4 13.exd4 ♗bd7 14.♖e1 maintains the pressure) 13.♗xd7 ♗xd7 14.dxc5 bxc5 15.♖a4± White has good prospects against the hanging pawns.

**11.♗e5!**

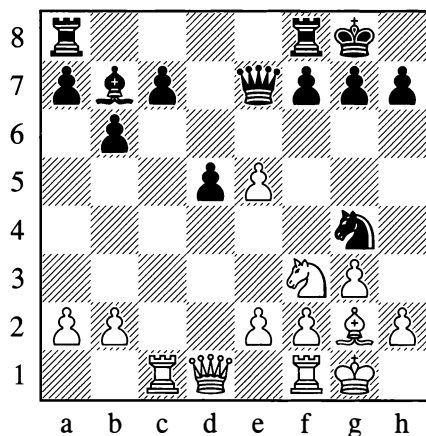
I like this aggressive idea, which pretty much forces Black to trade knights.

11...♗xe5

11...c5?! 12.♗xd7 ♗xd7 13.dxc5 bxc5 14.♗b3! c4 15.♗d4 gave White an obvious positional advantage in Mareco – C.E. Toth, Osasco 2012.

12.dxe5 ♗g4 13.♗f3 ♖e7

Another interesting path is: 13...c5 14.b4! (This is much more challenging than 14.h3 ♘h6 15.g4 ♗e7, when the position was unclear in Ragger – Salgado Lopez, Warsaw 2013.) 14...c4 15.♗d4 h5 16.♘h4! ♗e7 17.f4 ♗xb4 18.♘f5 White obtained a dangerous initiative for the pawn in the computer game Hannibal – Vitruvius, Internet 2013.

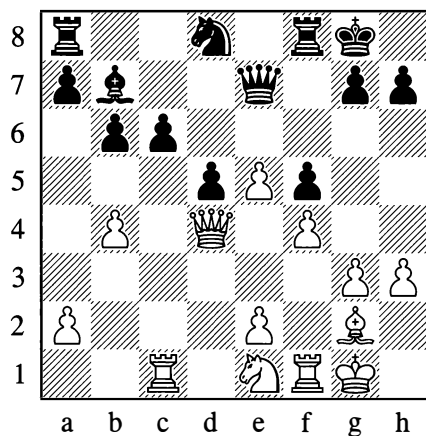


14.♗d4 f5 15.b4!

15.exf6N ♘xf6 16.b4 looks marginally more comfortable for White, but the text move is more ambitious.

15...c6 16.h3 ♘h6 17.♘e1! ♘f7 18.f4 ♘d8

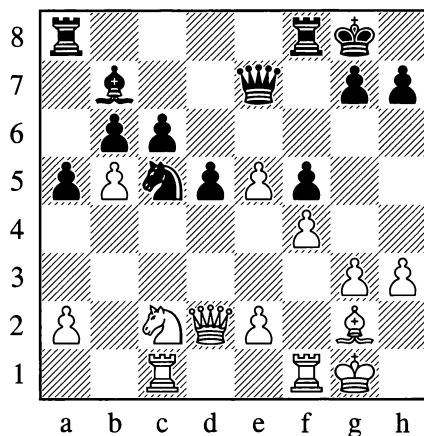
This position was reached in Novoa – Rudolf, Gibraltar 2013. Here the most logical continuation would have been:



19.♘c2N ♘e6 20.♗d3

White retains a positional advantage and is ready for ♘d4 next. The following line is critical:

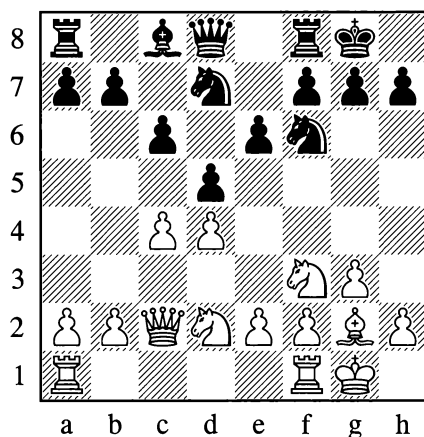
20...a5 21.b5 ♘c5 22.♗d2



22...cxb5 23.♙xd5† ♙xd5 24.♗xd5† ♖h8 25.♘e3

White is better thanks to his strong passed pawn and more threatening pawn majority.

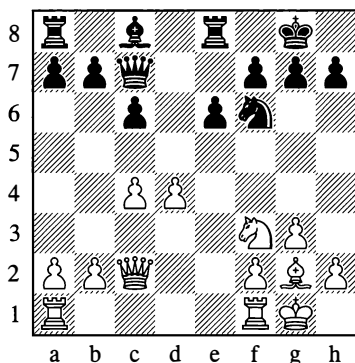
B3) 7...c6 8.♗c2 ♘bd7 9.0–0



This position has occurred in hundreds of games, but once again we will focus on a few key examples that best illustrate the main ideas.

9...b6

This seems best. 9...♞e8 allows 10.e4 with an easy advantage for White. A good example is: 10...dxe4 11.♟xe4 ♟xe4 12.♞xe4 ♟f6 13.♞c2 ♞c7



14.c5! Playing against Black's light-squared bishop is a basic idea in this type of position so, once the opportunity for c4-c5 pops up, I prefer not to wait and give Black a chance to play ...c5 himself. White's advantage is obvious, and it is not surprising that he has won most of the games from this position.

10.e4 ♟b7

Black can also exchange some pieces:

10...dxe4 11.♟xe4 ♟xe4 12.♞xe4 ♟b7 13.♞fd1

Once again, White will make it as hard as possible for Black to carry out ...c5.

13...♞c7

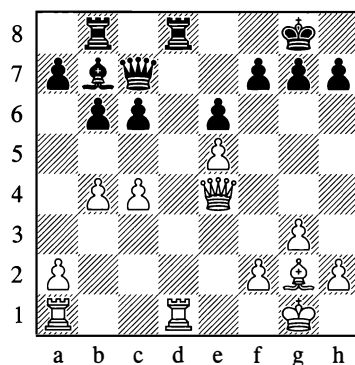
This is the most popular move. Notice that Black is keeping the knight on d7 to control the c5-square.

14.♟e5

This is the natural follow-up, but I found another attractive possibility: 14.c5!?N bxc5 15.♟g5! ♟f6 (After 15...g6 16.dxc5 ♟xc5 17.♞b4! ♟a6 18.♞h4 h5 19.♟e4 ♞fd8 20.♞ac1± White has a dangerous initiative and the weak dark squares are starting to tell) 16.♞e5 ♞fc8 17.♞xc7 ♞xc7 18.dxc5 ♟d5 19.♟e4 a5 20.♞d4± White keeps the better chances in the arising endgame.

14...♟xe5 15.dxe5 ♞fd8 16.b4 ♞ab8

This position occurred in Sheremeta – V. Tomashevsky, Pechora 2011. Here White could have obtained a clear advantage with:

**17.c5!N bxc5**

The immediate 17...♞d5 is met by 18.♞f4 ♞xe5 19.♞ac1 when Black is severely tied up.

18.bxc5 ♞d5

This is surely what White was concerned about, but he has a powerful reply.

19.♞c4! ♞xd1†

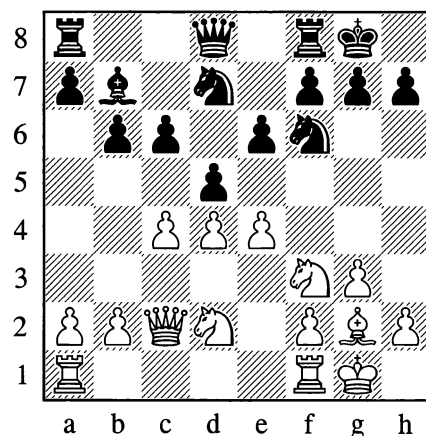
In the event of 19...♞xe5 20.♞ab1 ♞f8 21.♞d6 ♟a8 22.♞c3± Black's bishop is completely out of the game.

20.♞xd1 ♞xe5 21.♞a4! g5

After 21...♞xc5 22.♞b1! Black cannot avoid material losses.

22.♞xa7 ♟c8 23.a4±

Black is in serious trouble.



11.e5 ♖e8 12.cxd5

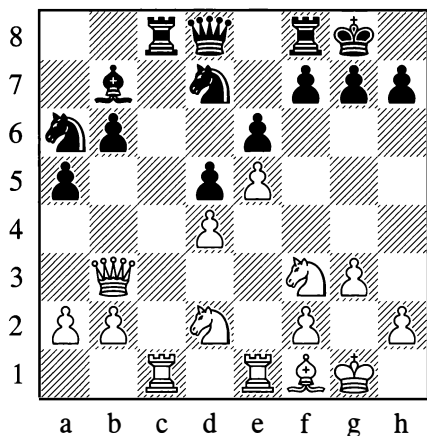
This time White should refrain from 12.c5, when 12...bxc5 13.dxc5 a5 14.♗f1 ♖c7 was unclear in Meier – Margvelashvili, Lubbock 2013.

12...cxd5 13.♗f1

A thematic idea to vacate the f1-square for the bishop.

13...a5

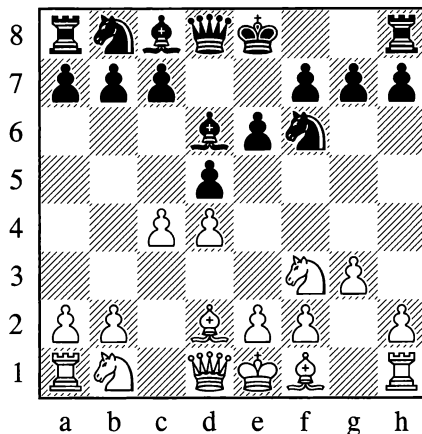
13...♙a6 was played in Tutisani – Savenkov, Maribor 2012, and now the natural 14.♖a4N ♙d3 15.♗e3 ♙g6 16.♗c1± would have given White a substantial plus.

14.♙f1 ♗c8 15.♖b3 ♖c7 16.♗ac1 ♖a6**17.♖b1!**

The knight is heading for c3 – a great square to control the queenside.

17...♖e7 18.♖c3 ♖ab8 19.♖b5

White was clearly better in Stohl – Kovacevic, Rabat 2003.

C) 5...♙d6

This retreat has become popular in recent years. It has been employed by several strong grandmasters and Black has statistically been doing well.

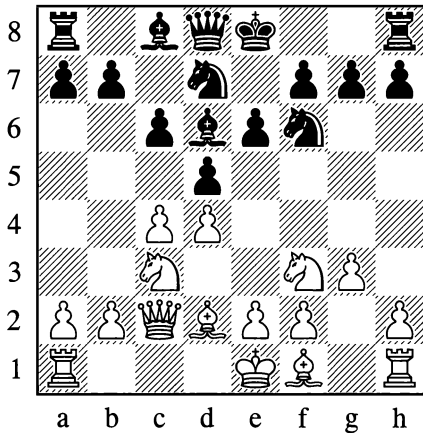
6.♖c3!

After the more popular 6.♙g2 c6 7.0–0 ♖bd7 there are a lot of games showing that Black seems to be okay.

I believe that the surprising knight move constitutes White's best chance for an opening advantage, the point being to prepare a quick e2–e4. We will consider C1) 6...c6 and C2) 6...0–0.

C1) 6...c6 7.♖c2 ♖bd7

It is also worth mentioning 7...♙b4 8.♙g2 dxc4 9.e4 b5, as in Rombaldoni – C. Horvath, Bratto 2008. Here 10.a4!N would have been strong, for example 10...a5 11.axb5 ♙xc3 12.bxc3 cxb5 13.0–0 and White has a great deal of compensation with Black's dark-squared bishop missing.



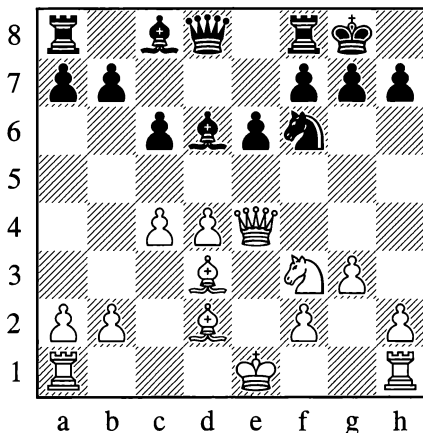
8.c4 dxe4 9.♘xe4 ♘xe4 10.♗xe4 0-0

Black has tried a couple of other moves:

10...c5 11.♙g2 0-0 12.♙c3 ♗e7 13.0-0 cxd4 14.♘xd4 ♘f6 15.♗c2± White emerged from the opening with a lot of pressure in Ax. Smith – Pedersen, Skanderborg 2010.

10...♘f6 11.♗c2 b6 12.♙g2 ♙b7 13.c5! ♙c7 14.0-0 ♘d5 15.♗fe1 h6 16.♘e5 0-0 17.♗ad1± The thematic plan of c4-c5 against the bishop on b7 yielded a clear advantage in Llanes Hurtado – Meier, Belfort 2012.

11.♙d3 ♘f6

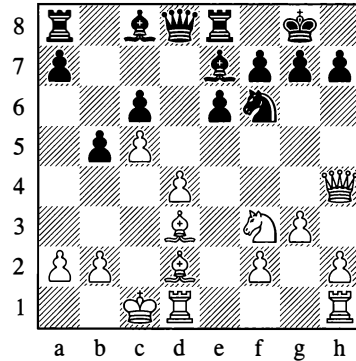


12.♗h4!

White should not be satisfied with the positional 12.♗e2, and can instead play for an attack.

12...b5

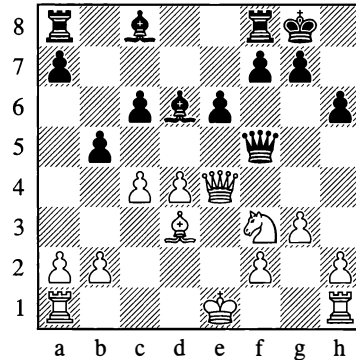
Another game continued 12...♗e8 13.0-0-b5 14.c5 ♙e7 Diermair – Matt, Linz 2011.



Here White could have easily seized the initiative with 15.♘e5N ♙b7 16.♙b1, for instance 16...a5 17.♙g5 h6 18.♙xf6 ♙xf6 19.♗e4± with a strong attack.

13.♙g5 h5

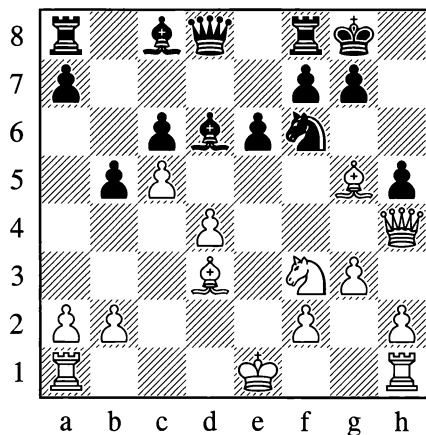
Black also fails to solve his problems with: 13...h6N 14.♙xf6 (after 14.♙xh6 gxh6 15.♗xh6 bxc4 White has a perpetual, but I don't see anything more) 14...♗xf6 15.♗e4 ♗f5



16.c5! (16.♗e3 is less clear after 16...♙b4† 17.♙e2 ♗h3 18.cxb5 e5! with some complications, as White's king is a bit exposed) 16...♙c7 17.♘e5 White is clearly better.

14.c5!

White has some other options, but it is difficult to argue with Ragger's execution of the attack.

**14...♙xc5 15.0-0-0 ♙c7 16.g4! ♙b7**

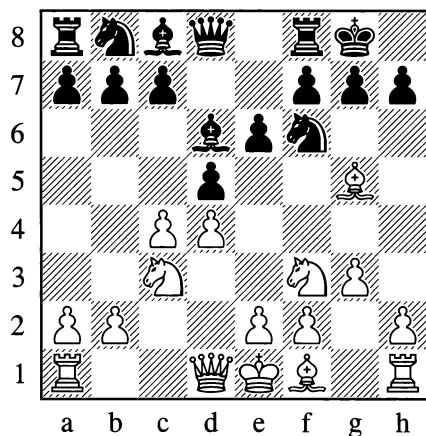
Other moves also fail to solve Black's problems, as the reader may verify if he wishes.

17.♙xf6 ♙xf6 18.g5

White had a winning attack in Ragger – Braun, Solingen 2010.

C2) 6...0-0 7.♙g5!

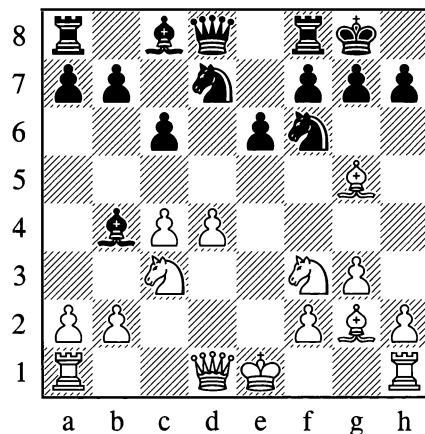
7.♙c2 c5! shows the advantage of Black's move order, so White should alter his plan from the previous variation.

**7...c6 8.♙g2 ♘bd7 9.e4**

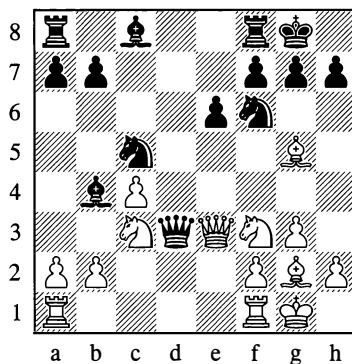
Definitely the most challenging idea.

9...dxe4 10.♘xe4 ♙b4† 11.♘c3!

11.♙d2 ♙xd2† 12.♘exd2 is well met by 12...e5! 13.dxe5 ♙e8 14.0-0 ♘xe5 15.♘xe5 ♙xe5 when Black was perfectly okay in Ghaem Maghami – Moiseenko, Jakarta 2013.

**11...♙a5**

Black has also tried 11...c5, without much success. 12.0-0 cxd4 13.♙xd4 ♘c5 (13...h6 14.♙f4 ♘b6 15.♘b5† does not help Black) 14.♙e3 ♙d3



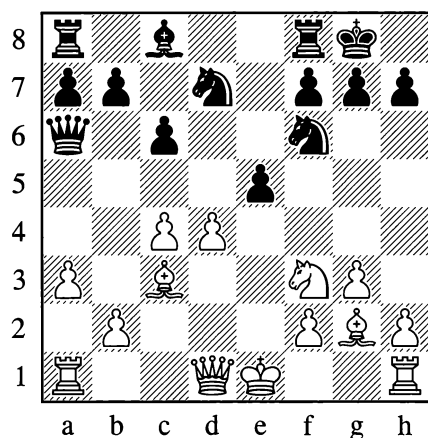
This was Kunin – Klek, Wunsiedel 2013, and now White could have secured a big advantage with 15.♙fd1!N ♙xe3 16.♙xe3±.

12.♙d2

12.0–0!? also deserves attention, since 12...♙xc3 13.bxc3 ♖xc3 14.♗e2 leaves White with great compensation.

12...e5 13.a3 ♙xc3 14.♙xc3 ♗a6

Black's position was rather suspicious in Meier – Adams, Baden-Baden 2013. White's strongest continuation would have been:



15.0–0!N e4

15...♗xc4 16.dxe5 ♖e4 17.♙d4±

16.♖d2 ♖b6 17.b3 ♗e8 18.♗e1±

With a serious advantage.

Conclusion

5...c5 is not really a serious equalizing attempt, and White gets a good game after exchanging on b4, followed by developing normally and preparing e2-e4.

5...♙xd2† 6.♖bxd2 0–0 7.♙g2 is also rather pleasant for White. Black's position is reasonably solid, but we saw that White could maintain pressure in all three of the lines examined.

5...♙d6 is the trickiest of the three main lines examined, since the stereotypical development of the bishop on g2 does not give White anything special. Fortunately for us, 6.♖c3! has a lot more bite. Depending on how Black continues, White will play either ♗c2 or ♙g5 next, intending to force through a quick e2-e4.